Public Statement Hearing - 8-21-19 - 19-G-0309 - 19-G-0310

NEW YORK STATE
DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC SERVICE

19-G-0309 Proceeding on Motion of the Commission as to the Rates, Charges, Rules and Regulations of The Brooklyn Union Gas Company d/b/a National Grid NY for Gas Service.

19-G-0310 Proceeding on Motion of the Commission as to the Rates, Charges, Rules and Regulations of KeySpan Gas East Corp. d/b/a National Grid for Gas Service.

Wednesday, August 21, 2019
Public Statement Hearing
2:00 p.m.
St. George Library Center
5 Central Ave
Staten Island, NY 10301

A.L.J. JAMES COSTELLO

COMMISSIONER DIANE BURMAN

A.L.J. COSTELLO: I've been assigned to this proceeding and to preside over this public statement hearing. Normally, we have our public statement hearings transcribed. However, there was some miscommunication between our office and the person who was to transcribe this. And, normally I'd ask you to speak slowly and clearly for the court reporter but now do so for the -- for the video recorder. And, Commissioner Burman is here with me. She's one of the decisionmakers. She's on the Commission -- Public Service Commission. She's one of the people that will be deciding what the utilities' rates and services will be going forward and I'd like to ask Commissioner Burman, if she'd like to make a statement.

COMMISSIONER BURMAN: Thank you. This is a selfie video. Thank you so much for having me today. I really am just a listener and a video recorder today. I'm going to bring back the comments that I hear to my fellow commissioners. I've been on the Commission since 2013. I'm a lifelong New Yorker and I'm very happy and blessed to be in Staten Island today. Thank you.

A.L.J. COSTELLO: Thank you

Commissioner Burman. So, what I'm going to do, we had three speakers sign up. One person has submitted her comments in writing, so I'll make sure that gets on the record. And, we're going to start today, with Ken Iwama.

MR. IWAMA: Good afternoon. It seems to be a little cooler here, so this is good. And, welcome Judge Costello, Commissioner Burman and -- and our representatives from National Grid. You know, my name's Ken Iwama. I'm the Vice President for Economic Development, Continuing Studies and Government Relations at the College of Staten Island. So, we have, obviously, a vested interest in the -- in the proceedings here today.

And, as I look at the summary of the rate case, that was set forth, you know, I'm looking at the proposed rates but I always -- always like to look at their rate case components, as well too because that's really the R.O.I., right?

What's the return on investment that you get for -- for any -- any type of increase? And, I -- I want to look at this a little more holistically than actually is set forth in some of these papers. And, one piece that is really not

flushed out, is whenever you talk about, you know, rate increase when it comes to mind, is to determine the corporate responsibilities, as well too.

So, what is National Grid giving back to the community beyond what is set forth in here, in terms of what is given back to -- to the Borough? And, personally from the College's standpoint, I can tell you that -- that National Grid is a great citizen in New York City but specific in this Borough. They have given the College of Staten Island hundreds of thousands of dollars, in terms of scholarships to our students, those who are pursuing Science degrees and specifically our engineering students.

That is remarkable and these are Staten Island residents. Their parents are from Staten Island and they are able to go to college and -- and pursue degrees in tech. Some hopefully go into National Grid, as well too because of the money that is given from -- from National Grid.

Secondly, and you -- you put it on the screen before and it's --it -- unfortunately sometimes when you put it as a bullet point, it doesn't become alive for people. And, you talk about

economic development, you talk about clean tech, I can -- I can take that off the screen and put it in reality for you. National Grid and our partners, they gave the College of Staten Island, the largest -- the largest grant through their clean tech initiative, given to anyone in the New York City Metro Area and that was just last year. That's two hundred fifty -- a quarter of a million dollars they gave us for a computer, to establish clean tech companies, right here on Staten Island, to employ people right in Staten -- to start businesses in Staten Island.

So, when you take those two things into consideration, as well as all the things that Carolyn Law do for the community because I see them everywhere, you know, I think that is not only a qualative piece but it's a quantitative piece that doesn't jump out from either the Power Point or -- or -- or the -- the documents they issued out. So, I just want to make sure that that's part of the record, in terms of again, the return on investment that National Grid gives. So, thank you very much.

A.L.J. COSTELLO: Thank you. And, just -- just as an explanation, what -- what happens,

is we'll have these transcribed. The transcripts usually take a week to two weeks to get posted on the Department of Public Service's website. You'll be able to see them there. And, we also, as part of the process, not only will Commissioner Burman go back and -- and talk to the other commissioners about what -- the comments made today but the Administrative Law Judges summarize all the comments from the public statement hearings, as well as comments that are submitted to the Department's website. We summarize them for the Commission, as well. So, the -- the next speaker will by Steven Grillo.

MR. GRILLO: Good afternoon, Judge Costello, Commissioner Burman. My name is Steven Grillo. I'm the first Vice President of the Staten Island Economic Development Corporation. We are a non-profit entity that has represented businesses in this Borough for twenty-five years. Currently we interact and represent 1,200 businesses in a variety of different capacities.

Our perspective is that the KEDNY Rate Case proposal results in an opportunity for a cleaner energy future. As New York transitions to a greener future, more investment in technology will assist

National Grid in meeting various goals. Increased investment will improve customer relations and help control the cost for customers in a variety of ways.

Staten Island is undergoing a major economic growth that will both improve the economic climate and challenge our infrastructure, including natural gas supply. A strong and reliable natural gas system is necessary to contribute to the overall economic health of the Borough. Investment by National Grid allowed by the successful conclusion of this rate case, will allow the company to achieve system modernization, technical and resiliency improvements, improve safety for workers and customer, service expansion and a cleaner energy future through sustained uility efforts.

In terms of economic development related to Staten Island, National Grid has been a tireless supporter and many people in this room, as Ken remarked, have been remarkable advocates. Various programs, including the rate discount programs, provide critical overlap into efforts, including the Industrial Business Owned Program, the Brownfield Opportunity Area Program administered by the State of New York and the New Opportunity --.

Additionally, National Grid's impact on the local community, includes supporting S.I.D.C.'s annual Green and Clean Festival, the Borough's only sustainability conference, a recently concluded local needs assessment for part of the Borough's first and only master plan, of which National Grid was a major sponsor and frequent interaction and assistance with business owners. S.I.D.C. firmly supports National Grid's request and thanks the Commission for its consideration.

A.L.J. COSTELLO: Thank you. May I take your statement? Thank you very much. Okay. We've come to the last speaker. We don't have many speakers this afternoon. So, I thank you all for attending and we'll be back this evening at the College of Staten Island, for another information -- information forum and public statement hearing and that's at 2800 Victory Boulevard, Building One, Center for the Arts. Thank you all.

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STATE OF NEW YORK

I, JUDITH SPRIGGS, do hereby certify that the foregoing was proofed by me, that the foregoing typewritten transcription consisting of pages 1 through 8, is a true transcript of the audio provided.

IN WITNESS WHEREOF, I have hereunto subscribed my name, this the 22nd day of September 2019.

JUDITH SPRIGGS,

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